explained: *'Of course they are also involved in all these killings. The Lashkar-e-Jhangvi took responsibility for the attacks but where is the government. Why doesn't it do something? It is a government failure*' (University teacher, Male, Quetta). Violence is a key variable in delegitimizing the state. The state not only is seen as unable to prevent the violence, but is actually blamed for initiating and sustaining it. Looking at the individual provinces, they all have different types of violence as a core part of the problem. Students pointed to the Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM),[15] political target killings in Karachi, the religiously inspired terrorism in Punjab, the sectarian and ethnic target killings in Balochistan and the terror groups in KP who mostly fight the Pakistani state. The radicalization of religious extremists feeds back into the violence, a theme echoed by students across this study, with one student pointing out that Pakistan is home to a large number of internationally banned groups who feed into the anti-state violent cycle. When discussing sectarian violence students highlighted the irony of Pakistan's origins: '*Besides the problem is which version of Islam are we trying to enforce in Pakistan*' (Focus Group, Private University[16]). However, most of the students also believed that these problems stemmed from a misunderstanding of Islam. '*We don't follow Islam. Religious awareness is given in masjids etc. but they sometimes express opinion that is not in Islam. Own limited knowledge, if we follow Islam our problems will be solved*' (Focus Group, Government University[17]); '*I think religious education needs to be reconsidered. We need to know what religion says. People say a lot but what is the true version*' (Focus Group, Private University[18]). In focus group discussions, there was no clear resolution as to what was the *right* Islam, with students highlighting differences between and within sects.

Alienation by the state

Alienation – a form of disconnect from the state – anger and frustration have been the result of a troubled relationship between citizens and their state. This is compounded by incompetence, corruption, pre-existing power structures and a feeling of powerlessness. Despite this fractured link with the state, the frustration and sense of powerlessness also points towards the state's inability to meet expectations concerning its responsibility to provide basic services such as electricity, gas and water; also at issue is the lack of employment for young people. The UNDP National Youth survey 2017 reminds us that young people aged 15–29 years make up 41.6 per cent of Pakistan's total labour force and that